

BME80G Final Part II: Writing Assignment & Oral Debate Preparation

DUE: Friday, May 29, 2026 (11:59 PM)

Google Docs version:

https://docs.google.com/document/d/1tuBUYmeHPR4wtvH3VZsxo7mMAIXMqQl6xVGnzkyrd_s/edit?usp=sharing

Name _____

Topic: _____

Side: _____

Formatting requirements: single-spaced · 11pt Arial · all five sections labeled · references

Total points: 70 points

Purpose: Before your oral debate, you need to arrive prepared, not just with an opinion, but with evidence, anticipated challenges, and a clear understanding of the opposing side. This written assignment is your preparation document. Each section builds a different skill you will need on debate day.

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Part A. Title (1 sentence, 5 pts)

Please provide a title that introduces your topic and the side you selected. A good title names the issue and signals your position.

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Part B. Background (~400 words, 10 pts)

Provide a neutral, factual overview of your topic that both sides of the debate could agree is accurate. Do not argue your position here (that comes below, in Part C). Your background should cover: (1) what the issue is and why it is ethically contested; (2) relevant scientific, medical, or statistical context, supported by at least two citations; and (3) who is most affected by this issue, and the values that are genuinely in conflict. After reading Part B, a classmate with no prior knowledge of your topic should understand the debate, not which side to take.

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Part C. Prepare your argument (~500 words, 15 pts)

This is the heart of your preparation. State your team's position clearly, build the case for it with distinct supporting arguments, and ground every claim in evidence.

1. **Thesis statement.** Write one to two sentences that precisely capture your team's position. It should be specific enough to be genuinely debatable, not a general observation that both sides could agree with. Bold and underline your thesis so it is easy to locate.

2. **Three to four supporting arguments (premises).** Each premise should make an independent point. If you removed one, the others should still stand on their own. Avoid restating the same idea in different words. Label each premise clearly in bold (e.g., "Premise 1: ...").
3. **Evidence for each premise.** Support every argument with specific evidence: data, peer-reviewed research, legal precedent, documented case studies, or expert testimony. Cite your sources.
4. **One normative ethical theory.** Connect your reasoning to at least one recognized ethical framework covered in class: Deontology, Utilitarianism, Virtue Ethics, Natural Law Theory, Contractarianism, or Ethic of Care. Underline the name of the theory when it appears.

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Part D. Anticipated Q&A Responses (4 questions × 100-200 words each, 20 pts)

This section is your preparation for the oral question and answer. Write at least **four questions** that someone who genuinely disagrees with your position would ask. For each question, write a response of 100–200 words. A strong response acknowledges the concern directly, explains why your position still holds using evidence and reasoning, and shows that you understand the nuance of the objection rather than simply restating your original argument. Label each pair clearly: Q1: [question] / Response 1: [answer].

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Part E. Opposition Analysis (~300 words, 15 points)

Strong debaters understand the opposing argument as well as their own. This section asks you to identify the **three strongest arguments on the other side** and explain, for each one, why your position still holds. The goal is not to dismiss the opposition but to show that your argument survives serious scrutiny.

Choose the arguments that are genuinely hardest for your side to answer and present them accurately. A useful test: could someone on the opposing team read your description and agree it fairly represents their view? For each opposing argument, write a rebuttal grounded in logic, evidence, or ethical reasoning. A rebuttal is not a restatement of your own position; it explains specifically where the opposing argument falls short or what it fails to account for. Label each response clearly: "**Rebuttal:** [your response]." Write each rebuttal concisely enough that a teammate could deliver it out loud without hesitation.

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References & Annotated Bibliography (5 points)

Please note: there is an expectation to include a **minimum of 5 credible sources** in your submission. Credible sources include peer-reviewed journal articles, government or public health agency publications,

academic books, and recognized medical or ethics organizations. Wikipedia, opinion blogs, and general news articles do not count as primary sources.

For each source, include one annotation sentence explaining specifically how it supports your team's argument.

We are not critical of reference formatting, but encourage the **Chicago Manual of Style** or a variation of it. This style typically includes: authors' names, title of the article (in quotation marks), title of the journal (in italics), publication year, and volume/issue numbers where applicable.

REFERENCES

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